

biotech crops. In 2008, developing countries out-numbered industrial countries by 15 to 10, and this trend is expected to continue with 40 countries, or more, expected to adopt biotech crops by 2015, the final year of the second decade of commercialisation.

With health and safety concerns, each country has adopted its own stringent norms for GM crops. The US Food and Drug Administration works in collaboration with the Environmental Protection Agency to vet biotech crop clearances and follows an established procedure in which it consults experts who are sworn to confidentiality. Food Canada also follows a similar procedure. But Australia has enacted the exclusive Gene Technology Act in 2002 to set up the most elaborate regulatory mechanism wherein everything is transparent and timelines are specified for completion of

tasks and clearances. As agriculture is not a major enterprise with the paucity of land and farming largely corporatised, EU members have a common regulatory mechanism that is inspired by trade considerations and consumer preferences as most of them are net importers of food crops. While Eastern Europe is rapidly joining the GM bandwagon, in Western Europe the issues are not related to science and technology but are of a political nature and influenced by ideological views of activist groups.

The adoption of biotech crops in developing countries between 2009 to 2015 will depend on the effective operation of appropriate, responsible and cost/time-effective regulatory systems; a strong political will; a secure supply of food, feed, and fibre and a supply of crops that can meet the priority needs of these countries.

“It is a disaster. It is unethical. No time was given to us as members to review the findings.”

PUSHPA M. BHARGAVA, Molecular Biologist

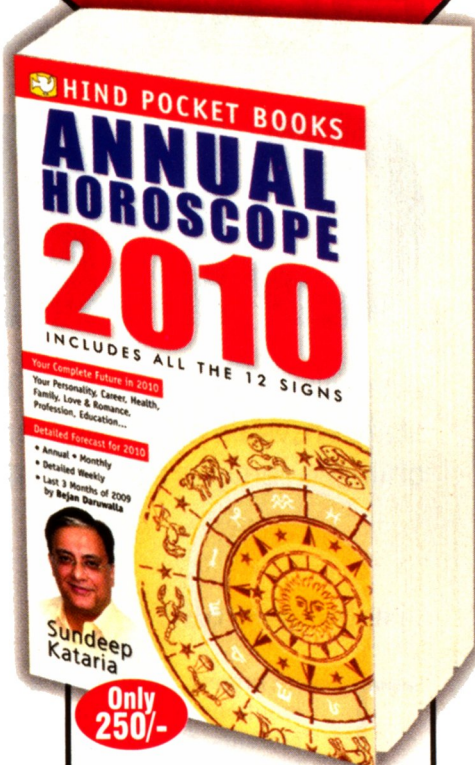
development and immune responsiveness. Studies in other countries have found allergies, disturbance in immune system responses, damage to organs like kidneys and liver, alterations in blood chemistry, slower growth and development. In real life instances in India, there is the phenomenon of animals falling sick after grazing in Bt cotton fields and, in some cases, dying, and workers reporting allergies. But these cases have not been investigated fully by the health authorities.

Some NGOs have raised concerns about the absence of labelling laws in India. Groups like the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) have warned that without a regulatory regime in place, it would be impossible to monitor the impact of such new food products. “In India, there is no labelling regime for genetically modified foods which will give consumers

a choice to make a decision whether they want to consume genetically modified food or not. Till the time this is done, regulators should not clear edible GM crops,” says CSE Director Sunita Narain.

Whatever needs to be done, whether it is clearing doubts NGOs and activists have about the independence of the GEAC or addressing health and safety concerns, the Government now needs to do it swiftly. The country cannot afford to ignore biotechnology options to increase agricultural productivity as it does hold the promise of a second green revolution. But, for the moment, it has to evolve stringent and transparent testing before GM foods are released into the market to ensure these are safe for human consumption. For want of a proper regulation in place, an opportunity to meet food security needs must not be lost. ■

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